charge, woollens.

It was in 1582, too, that Akbar invited a man called Amir Fathullah Shirazi to his court. A man of many and varied talents, from astrology to mechanics,[39] and capable, equally, of 'accompanying the emperor on hunting parties, with a rifle on his shoulder, and a powder keg in his waistband',[40] Fathullah may have mirrored something of Akbar's own physical and intellectual adventurism; and he became one of the stars of Akbar's court.

He also became a good friend of Abul Fazl's, who wrote of Fathullah that 'If the books of antiquity should be lost, the Amir will restore them'.[41] This was high praise coming from a man who had, in fact, restored a book himself. Once, it seems, a rare manuscript half burnt by fire came to Abul Fazl. The scholar took on the challenge, 'cut away the burnt portions, pasted new paper to each page, and then commenced to restore the missing halves of each line, in which attempt, after many thoughtful perusals, he succeeded'. When, later, an undamaged copy of the book was found, Abul Fazl's restored version 'presented so many points of extraordinary coincidence, that his friends were not a little astonished at the thoroughness with which [he] had worked himself into the style and mode of thinking of a difficult author'.[42]

Abul Fazl and Amir Fathullah were not only similar in their intellectual rigour, they were also alike in how they narrated the destiny of their emperor.

The early pages of the *Akbarnama* include three horoscopes of its subject – one by Maulana Chand, who was there at Akbar's birth, keeping a close eye on Hamida's contractions; another by Jyotik Rai, based on Indian calculations, as opposed to the maulana's Greek ones; and a third by Fathullah.

It is Fathullah's reading that appears to aim, much like the *Akbarnama*, to project the emperor's life as ordained. Thus, Fathullah found that Akbar's marital alliances with 'the ruling families of India' were fated by the stars, as was the 'depart[ure]' of Humayun when Akbar reached 'the years of discretion'. He even discovered that the emperor's brother (who else but poor Mirza Hakim) would 'be of no account alongside [Akbar's] glory'.

Much like the miracles and genealogies that fill the *Akbarnama*, such a